

analyst Prof. A. Narayana. "But the Congress is in a more formidable position this time, being the ruling party." At the core of the Congress campaign, therefore, are the welfare schemes, or guarantees, that the Siddaramaiah-led government has rolled out since coming to power in May last year.

The Welfare Card

In the past 10 months, the Congress has spent Rs 33,468 crore on its guarantees, which reach an estimated 45 million beneficiaries in Karnataka. A senior government official, citing surveys, claims that more than 95 per cent of the intended beneficiaries have been covered so far. "There has been no corruption and these programmes were implemented irrespective of the community the beneficiary belongs to," says Vinay Kumar Sorake, who took over as Congress's campaign committee chairman for Karnataka on April 5. According to him, this gives the party a "never-before opportunity" to swing votes away from the BJP and shore up its seat tally. The Congress's last big haul in a Lok Sabha election was in 1999, when it won 18 seats and a vote share of 45.4 per cent. It has been downhill since then as the BJP emerged as a firm favourite in subsequent parliamentary polls. In the past 20 years, the Congress's best performance in the state came ironically in 2014—when the party was at its lowest ebb nationally—with nine seats and a vote share of 41.2 per cent. Incidentally, the party was in power at the time in Karnataka with Siddaramaiah serving his first term as chief minister.

The main election issues this time, says Sorake, are price rise and unemployment. While the Congress is relying on its guarantees, the BJP's outreach to voters is equally focused on the Modi government's flagship schemes. There are 30 million beneficiaries of central welfare schemes in Karnataka, Union home minister Amit Shah told a convention of BJP booth-level workers in Bengaluru on April 2. At that meeting, however, Shah opened up a fresh battlefront when he accused the Siddaramaiah government of delaying the submission of its proposal seeking drought relief by three months, owing to which funds could not be released on time.

WHAT THEY ARE BETTING ON

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

- PM Narendra Modi's charisma and flagship schemes
- Better ground-level coordination with workers of alliance partner JD(S) to ensure successful transfer of votes
- Field new faces to overcome anti-incumbency
- Highlight failures of the year-old Siddaramaiah regime and the Congress

CONGRESS

- Maximise goodwill from the Karnataka government's five welfare guarantees
- Highlight the Centre's 'discrimination' in fund allocation, delay in drought relief
- Focus on price rise, unemployment, voter fatigue with the BJP
- Field candidates who can exploit BJP dissidence

Centre vs State

Countering Shah's allegation at a hurriedly convened press conference the same day, Karnataka revenue minister Krishna Byre Gowda accused him of "adding insult to injury". Facing a widespread drought that has afflicted 223 of the state's 236 sub-districts, the